The power struggle within the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) took a significant turn on June 10 when party supremo Sharad Pawar announced the appointment of his daughter and Lok Sabha MP Supriya Sule and former Union minister Praful Patel as the working presidents of the party. With Sule thus anointed as her father's political heir, all eyes are on her mercurial cousin and Maharashtra leader of opposition Ajit Pawar. Ajit refused to comment immediately after his cousin's appointment as the effective No. 2 in the NCP. He later denied that he was upset. "I am very content," he told the media. "This is unnecessary (speculation)." Ajit also tweeted in support of the newly-appointed functionaries.

He would have seen it coming. Just when a group in the party, which owed its allegiance to him, was rumoured to be eager to break ranks with the Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi (MVA) and join hands with the BJP, Pawar Sr, in a surprise move, announced on May 2 that he will be stepping down as the national president of the party. The action was seen as one aimed to galvanise the party rank and file and show his nephew his place. The gambit succeeded—amid cries of dismay, NCP functionaries, cadre and even national leaders across party lines called on the NCP patriarch and asked him to reconsider his move. Relenting, Pawar withdrew his decision on May 5, emerging the stronger from the churn.

Though Ajit himself denied that he was seeking any truck with the BJP, a group of NCP leaders who are being probed by central investigation agencies on various charges, were allegedly anxious that they jump ship. Senior BJP leader and Union minister Narayan Rane had said that Ajit was on the *seemaresha* (border) of the BJP. The saffron party would welcome him with open arms as Ajit is also said to command the loyalty of a significant number of NCP legislators. He also formed a shortlived government with them in 2019.

Incidentally, when Pawar announced his decision to step down at a function to release the updated version of his autobiography, Ajit was the lone NCP leader who supported his decision, initially snapping at those who called on Pawar



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Ajit Pawar's Political Journey So Far

- Born on July 22, 1959, to Ashatai and Anantrao Pawar, the elder brother of Sharad Pawar
- Joined politics through the co-operatives sector
- Elected to Lok Sabha from Baramati in 1991; months later, vacated seat for uncle Sharad Pawar, who became Union defence minister
- In the Congress-NCP government that came to power in 1999, Ajit held cabinet portfolios like water, energy, and finance. Was deputy CM from 2010–2014
- Was seen as Pawar's political heir till cousin Supriya Sule joined politics in 2006
- In 2019, formed short-lived government with BJP. As MVA government came to power, Ajit was made deputy CM, with the finance portfolio
- Married to Sunetra Pawar; has two sons, Parth and Jay